surprising I'm not sure now how it all happened. My mum remembers me being spotted playing in the park and a bloke called Stuart Underwood knocking on our front door to ask about me. My dad, though, reckons there was an advertisement about a new boys' soccer team in the local paper and that afternoon over at Chase Lane was a sort of trial. Either way, I'm really grateful—and proud—that I was part of that first Ridgeway Rovers team. And the man who set up the team had a lot to do with me making a future for myself in the game.

Stuart Underwood's a massive bloke. About 76 inches, with a big booming voice and this fantastic presence about him. He was a bit of a drill sergeant type. I was a little scared of him at first. He could be pretty tough: no matter how young you were, if you weren't playing well, in a game or in training, he'd tell you that you were rubbish and needed to do better, instead of just jollying you along. Stuart was honest with you. But he wasn't one of those dads who stood on the touchline at kids' games, bawling and screaming. He had this softness about him as well. His own son Robert played in the team, but Stuart seemed like a father figure to all of us. And he had this dream about creating a really good team.

Every single boy just loved playing for Stuart and we had this fantastic team spirit. He'd organize for Ridgeway to play in competitions in Holland and Germany, so we gained the same sort of experience as a professional playing in an international tournament. Other fathers got involved, too. My dad took on some of the coaching. So did a man called Steve Kirby, whose son Ryan played for Ridgeway and ended up playing against me ten years later in the League. Dad was always a fit man and he did running with us, as well as working on our technique. Steve was a bit of a tactician and he used to do positional play, runs off the ball and that kind of thing. A lot of the time, all three of them would be there and we'd split into smaller groups: there weren't many boys our age who got that much attention paid to their training. The three of them—Steve, Stuart and my dad—used to argue a lot, but it was all in the cause. They were honest people wanting to make the team as good as they could.

It worked. I don't know where Stuart found them, but we had some really good players: Ryan Kirby, Micah Hyde, who's now at Watford, Jason Brissett, who was at Bournemouth last I heard, and Chris Day, who was a lanky center-forward for us but ended up playing in goal for QPR. It was all about the team, though. Stuart Underwood's son, Robert, was a perfect example. To be honest, he didn't have great ability to start with but because he worked so hard at his game, he made himself into a good team player. That was credit to